



Week 2: Paid Social Strategy

Team Name: Team 2

Sedinam Gbeku, Elikem Kwame Dzakpasu, Mahum Faizan, Qandeel Fatima, Hafsa Hashim, Patricia Etim Ita, Aqsa Fatima

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Introduction

As competition for young talent grows, organizations are increasingly using digital advertising to promote internships and early-career opportunities. This report analyzes how major competitors market to interns and job seekers across platforms like Facebook, Instagram, and LinkedIn. Using real ad examples and publicly available tools, it compares their ad formats, targeting, messaging, and engagement. The goal is to identify what works well for competitors and highlight opportunities for Excelerate to stand out in its digital advertising strategy.

1. Visual Evidence: Competitor Advertising Activity

Visual evidence was drawn directly from Meta's Facebook Ad Library and LinkedIn Ads Library, as compiled in the accompanying research document. The reviewed advertisements represent a mix of Meta (Facebook and Instagram) and LinkedIn placements, targeting students, graduates, and early-career professionals.

Across competitors, ads consistently rely on visually direct creatives: bold headlines, minimal text, and strong call-to-action buttons such as "Apply Now," "Send Message," or "Learn More." Video-based formats, particularly reels and short clips, are dominant among higher-performing competitors, suggesting alignment with youth consumption habits.

Competitor Ads (Meta: Facebook & Instagram)

Tools Used - Facebook Ad library

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LetsUpgrade
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Thousands of students have already joined this free program.
Don't sit out.
If you're 18–24, you qualify.
Jump in before seats fill.




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Learn a New Skill for Free
Bored of watching...

Apply Now

FB:ME
Get Free VERIFIED...
Earn a completion...

Apply Now

Bored of watching tutorial...

Earn a completion ...

Competitor Ads (LinkedIn)

Tools Used - LinkedIn Ad library

LinkedIn Ad Library

Ad Details

Handshake
Promoted

With Handshake Plus, we'll automate outreach for your open job so you can hire the talent you need—fast.

NEED SOME TIME BACK THIS HOLIDAY SEASON?

Hiring great candidates on Handshake is simple.

Boost your job on Handshake today

Sign Up

Glassdoor
Promoted

A small taste of revenge for those who've been impacted by recent layoffs: employers are paying the price, too. Turns out, sav...see more

Layoffs GD News

Learn more

LinkedIn Ad Library

Ad Details

ZipRecruiter
Promoted

ZipRecruiter now integrates with Workday: instant job posts, screening, and candidate profiles – less admin, more great hires.

ZipRecruiter

Workday Certified.
Hiring Simplified.

ZipRecruiter's Workday Integration Just Got Better

Big news: We're now officially Workday Certified!

Learn more

2. Comparative Analysis of Excelerate and Competitors

Criteria	Excelerate	LetsUpgrade	Triumphs Academy	BlueBoxx	Handshake	Computron
Ad Formats Used	Reels, static posts, carousel	Carousel	Static image	Carousel	Single-image & document ads	Static image
Target Audience	Students, fresh graduates	Students aged 18–24	Students & job seekers	Entry-level professionals	Early-career talent & recruiters	Students
Messaging Style	Career growth, flexibility, virtual experience	Urgency and free access	Skill training emphasis	Transformation & incentives	Professional credibility & hiring efficiency	Practical skill acquisition
Call-to-Action	Apply Now / Register	Apply Now	Send Message	Send Message	Learn More / Sign Up	Learn More
Observed Engagement	Moderate engagement, typically 10–35 likes and 0–6 comments per ad.	High engagement, averaging 20–60 likes and 5–15 comments, indicating strong audience interest.	Low engagement, generally 5–10 likes and minimal comments.	Low–medium engagement, around 8–25 likes with occasional comments, higher on incentive-led ads.	Strong LinkedIn engagement with 30–100+ reactions and consistent professional comments.	Low engagement, usually 5–12 likes and little to no interaction.

Interpretive Analysis: Competitors demonstrating higher engagement levels consistently simplify their value proposition. LetsUpgrade’s success, for example, is tied to urgency-based framing and low-friction CTAs, which reduce decision fatigue for young audiences. Handshake’s comparatively strong LinkedIn

performance stems from its professional authority and alignment with institutional trust.

Excelerate occupies a strong middle position, offering flexibility and virtual experience, but does not yet fully capitalize on outcome-driven storytelling or urgency-based hooks. This presents a clear opportunity for strategic refinement rather than reinvention.

3. Strategic Insights from Competitor Performance

- Several strategic patterns emerge across competitor advertising efforts. First, short-form video has become the dominant engagement driver on Meta platforms. Reels outperform static images by capturing attention within the first three seconds, which is critical for youth audiences.
- Second, urgency-based messaging such as limited seats, deadlines, or free access consistently outperforms evergreen branding campaigns. This indicates that youth audiences respond more strongly to perceived scarcity than long-term brand promises.
- Third, LinkedIn ads succeed when positioned around credibility and outcomes rather than emotion. Platforms that emphasize employability, verified skills, and institutional partnerships gain stronger traction among graduates and recruiters alike.

4. Opportunities for Differentiation for Excelerate

- Excelerate has a clear opportunity to differentiate itself by combining credibility with human-centered storytelling. Unlike competitors that rely solely on urgency or incentives, Excelerate can position itself as a long-term career accelerator supported by measurable outcomes.
- Key differentiation opportunities include structured storytelling from past interns, showcasing real project work and post-program outcomes. Additionally, Excelerate's AI-powered learning tools should be framed not as features, but as guarantees of efficiency, personalization, and employability.
- By aligning emotional storytelling with data-backed outcomes, Excelerate can occupy a premium yet accessible position within the internship ecosystem.